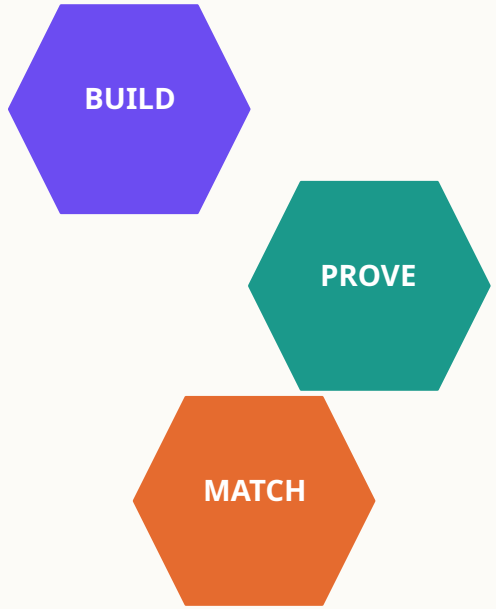
Path2Work

PROVE BEFORE HIRE

Early-career IT readiness & verified talent platform

Helping IT students prove they can do the job before someone gives them their first job.



Build evidence. Prove readiness. Reach the right employer.

1. Problem crystallisation

Move from “youth unemployment” to a specific, solvable entry-level IT problem.

Broad symptoms are hard to design around. The root problem must explain the user, cause and consequence.

SYMPTOM

“IT graduates struggle to find opportunities.”

ROOT PROBLEM

Final-year IT students and recent graduates often have qualifications and projects, but employers lack a trusted, role-specific signal that shows whether they can actually perform entry-level work.

Our design opportunity:

Create verified proof of capability before formal recruitment begins — then turn that proof into a clearer readiness signal for both the student and the employer.

2. Feedback → pivot

We used the panel and mentor feedback to narrow the product instead of adding more features.

BEFORE

Generic youth employment platform

- Candidate profiles
- Readiness assessment
- Job / internship matching
- CV & career guidance
- AI assistant

Panel signal: CAN USE ✓ CAN BUY × WOULD PAY: R0

NOW

Verified early-career IT readiness

- Specific niche: IT students + recent graduates
- Role-specific WorkProof challenges
- Skills Passport with trust levels
- Build → Explain → Adapt verification
- Employer-ready pre-qualified talent pool

Key shift: from “help me find a job” → “help me prove I can do the work.”

3. Start narrow: the target market

The MVP focuses on South African IT students and recent graduates — not every unemployed young person.

USER STAGES

1st-year IT student Build foundations

Future pipeline

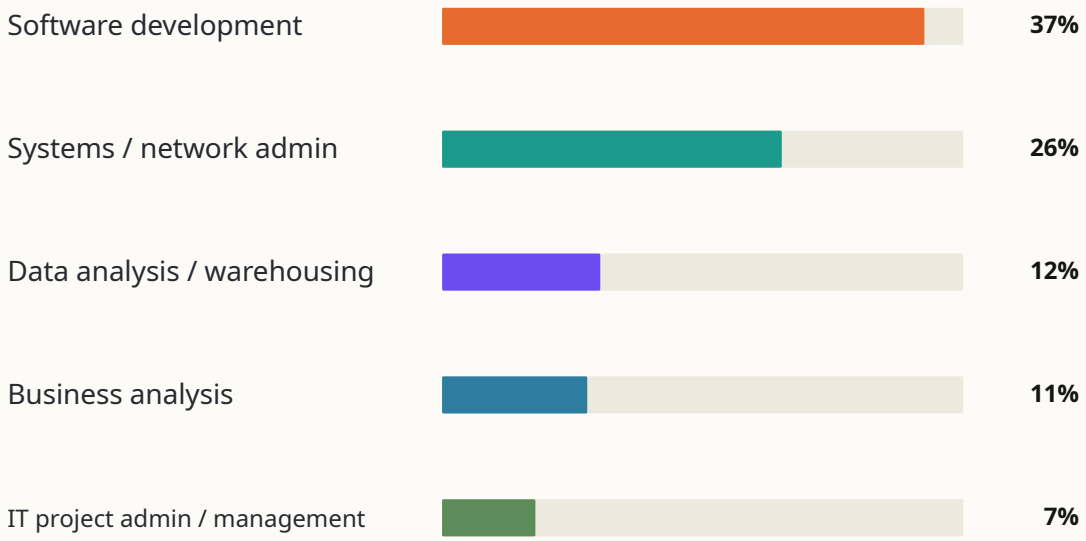
Final-year IT student Prove job readiness

PRIMARY MVP

Recent IT graduate Convert proof into interviews

PRIMARY MVP

MARKET SIGNAL — youth IT roles



MVP pathways: Junior Software Developer • Junior Data Analyst • IT Support / Cloud

Source: Pnet Job Market Trends Report, May 2025 — youth IT job roles in South Africa.

4. Compete on proof — not on job listings

We do not need to beat LinkedIn, Indeed or OfferZen at what they already do well.

LINKEDIN	INDEED	OFFERZEN	PATH2WORK
Professional identity	**Broad job discovery**	**Curated tech hiring**	**Proof before hire**
Profiles, networks, career history and recruiter discovery.	High-volume vacancy search and application workflows.	Candidate curation, matching and tech recruitment marketplace.	Role-specific WorkProof + readiness + verified evidence for students with little formal experience.
Path2Work can create verified evidence that a candidate later shares there.	Path2Work prepares the candidate before application.	Marketplace employers still own their technical/background checks	**We become the pre-employment readiness layer before the employer's own process.**

Positioning: LinkedIn records your career. OfferZen helps move a tech career. Path2Work helps prove you are ready to start one.

OfferZen Docs (2025–2026): Marketplace candidates are curated; employers remain responsible for technical assessments and background checks.

5. The unique value proposition

Value is not the feature list. It is the better outcome for the student and the employer.

For IT students & grads → **who lack trusted job proof** → **Path2Work builds verified evidence** → **before formal vetting**

“A CV says what you know. Path2Work shows what you can do.”



6. Trust layer: filter fraud without pretending fraud disappears

If Path2Work claims “verified capability”, every badge must explain what was actually verified.

EVIDENCE TRUST LEVELS

1	**SELF-DECLARED**	Candidate claims the skill
2	**EVIDENCE ATTACHED**	Project / repository / certificate linked
3	**SOURCE VERIFIED**	Ownership or institution source checked
4	**PATH2WORK ASSESSED**	Controlled WorkProof evaluated
5	**EMPLOYER VERIFIED**	Employer-sponsored challenge / review

PROOF OF UNDERSTANDING

1	**BUILD**	Can the candidate complete the task?
2	**EXPLAIN**	Can they explain their choices?
3	**ADAPT**	Can they modify it when requirements change?

Trust principle: verify the evidence and the candidate’s understanding — not just what they typed into a profile.

7. Fit into company vetting — do not replace it

The employer keeps its ATS, assessment and interview process. Path2Work improves who reaches that process.

Illustrative employer funnel



PATH2WORK DOES

- Verify baseline capability
- Explain readiness gaps
- Rank against company criteria

COMPANY STILL DOES

- Identity / background checks
- Internal technical assessment
- Interview + final hiring decision

WHY EMPLOYERS CARE

Spend scarce screening time on candidates who have already demonstrated the basics.

Illustrative numbers — to be validated with employer partners.

8. Business model hypothesis

The student should not be the payer. The organisations receiving hiring and talent-development value should pay.

WHO USES?

IT students & recent graduates

Free core access

WHO PAYS?

Employers first; institutions later

B2B / B2B2C

WHY PAY?

Reduce screening noise + build qualified early-talent pipeline

Time + signal

WHAT WE SELL?

Qualified shortlist • sponsored WorkProof • talent pipeline

Employer products

Potential employer offers

Sponsored WorkProof campaign	Company-defined challenge → qualified candidate pool
Qualified shortlist	Candidates already meeting baseline criteria
Talent pipeline subscription	Ongoing access to verified early-career IT talent
Institution analytics — later	Readiness / skills-gap insights for cohorts

Important

Revenue model is a hypothesis. We still need employer willingness-to-pay validation.

9. Hackathon MVP: smallest proof of value

Do not build a marketplace. Prove one complete role-specific journey.



MUST

Role profile • WorkProof • evidence score • Skills Passport • employer view

SHOULD

Readiness feedback • next-best-action • basic fraud checks

LATER

Real client marketplace • payments • full ATS integration • many job families

Core demo question: “Can this student demonstrate entry-level capability for this specific IT role?”

10. What we know, assume and need to validate

The next mentor conversation should attack the risky assumptions — not just praise the idea.

WE KNOW

- The original broad concept was usable
- The payer/value story was weak
- IT students need a clearer proof pathway
- The challenge explicitly values skills verification + practical experience

WE ASSUME

- Employers value WorkProof as a pre-screening signal
- Build–Explain–Adapt increases trust
- 3 initial IT pathways are narrow enough
- Employers may fund challenges / shortlists

VALIDATE NEXT

- Which role should launch first?
- What proof would employers trust?
- What fraud controls are essential?
- Would employers pay per campaign, shortlist or subscription?

MENTOR ASK: Help us choose the first role + define the minimum evidence an employer would trust enough to shortlist a candidate.